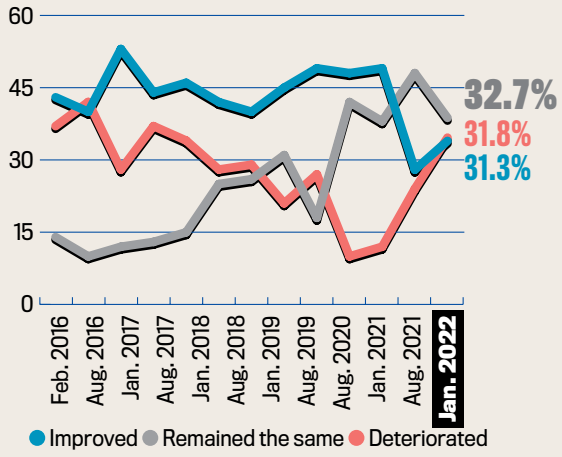
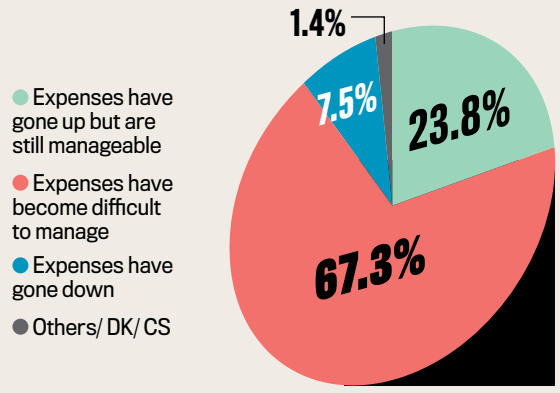
Q. HOW HAS YOUR ECONOMIC STATUS CHANGED SINCE NARENDRA MODI TOOK CHARGE AS PRIME MINISTER?



Q. HOW DO YOU COMPARE YOUR CURRENT DAILY EXPENSES TO THOSE OF LAST YEAR?



(DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say)

(consumer price index), rose to 5.59 per cent in December 2021, the highest in five months. The country's unemployment rate was at a four-month high in December, at 7.91 per cent, up from 7 per cent and 7.75 per cent in November and October, according to data from CMIE (Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy). The urban unemployment rate rose to 9.3 per cent in December, while rural employment stood at 7.28 per cent, a significant rise from the 8.21 per cent and 6.44 per cent recorded in November. The pandemic continues to hurt the services sector, with curbs to control crowding denting firms in retail and hospitality.

In terms of future expectations, 31.1 per cent of respondents said they saw the economy improving in the next six months, while 21.9 per cent were of the opinion that it would remain the same. While 29.2 per cent said it would get worse, this was down from the 32 per cent who said so in August 2021. On incomes, an overwhelming 30.1 per cent of respondents were optimistic about their incomes improving, nearly double the 17 per cent in August. At the same time, 27.3 per cent believed their incomes would remain the same (down from 45 per cent in August), while 28.9 per cent expected their income to fall (down from 34 per cent).

67% OF THOSE AGED 45–54 SAY **THE GOVT. HAS DONE ENOUGH TO ADDRESS COVID'S ECONOMIC DAMAGE.** ONLY **54%** OF THOSE AGED 25–34 **AGREE**

However, amidst the optimism, there are also indicators that inflation has become a serious problem. A whopping 67.3 per cent of respondents said their current daily expenses had become difficult to manage compared to last year, while only 23.8 per cent said that their expenses were still manageable (despite having risen). Inflation has remained a concern through 2021, not just in India, but across the world. Increases in commodity prices have hurt the competitiveness of businesses, whether small, medium or large. Wholesale inflation remained in double-digit territory for most of 2021—at 13.56 per cent in December, 14.23 per cent in November and 13.83 per cent in October. According to a statement from the Union ministry of commerce and industry, the high inflation in December 2021 was primarily a result of price increases for mineral oils, basic metals, crude petroleum and natural gas and food products, among other goods. Although most firms got back to business in the second half of 2021 after Covid-induced restrictions were relaxed, the economic uncertainty has impacted hiring to a great degree, especially in contact-intensive sectors like hospitality and retail. According to CMIE, some six million salaried jobs were lost in November. As many as 45 per cent of respondents said the unemployment situation in the country as 'very serious', though this was down